

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Marine biologist Aisha Obi studied bioluminescence in a species of deep-sea squid found in the Mariana Trench. Obi observed that the squid produce light from organs on their undersides, matching the faint sunlight filtering from above. This counter-illumination eliminates the squid's silhouette when viewed from below, making them nearly invisible to predators hunting from deeper water. Obi also noted that a species of deep-sea anglerfish in the same habitat uses bioluminescence differently, dangling a glowing lure above its mouth to attract prey.

According to the text, why do the squid produce bioluminescence from their undersides?

- A: To eliminate their silhouette when viewed from below, making them difficult for predators to detect
- B: To attract smaller prey organisms toward the light, enabling the squid to ambush them
- C: To communicate mating signals to other members of the same species during breeding season
- D: To startle predators with a sudden flash of light, creating an opportunity to escape

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage says the squid use counter-illumination to eliminate their silhouette from predators below. B is the classic entity-swap trap: it describes what the ANGLERFISH does (lure prey with light), not the squid. C and D describe plausible but unmentioned bioluminescence uses. TRICK: When a passage describes two organisms with different behaviors, the test swaps them. Match each behavior to its correct organism.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Materials scientist Lucia Ferreira analyzed ancient Roman concrete structures that have survived in Mediterranean harbors for over 2,000 years. Ferreira found that the concrete contains volcanic ash from the region near Mount Vesuvius. When exposed to seawater, the volcanic ash triggers a chemical reaction that produces aluminous tobermorite crystals within the concrete matrix. These crystals grow over centuries, continuously reinforcing the material and filling microscopic cracks, which is why Roman harbor concrete has actually grown stronger with age rather than deteriorating.

According to the text, what role does the volcanic ash play in Roman concrete's durability?

- A: It creates an impermeable outer layer that prevents seawater from penetrating the concrete surface
- B: It reacts with seawater to produce crystals that reinforce the concrete and fill cracks over time, causing the material to strengthen with age
- C: It absorbs the mechanical stress of ocean waves, reducing the physical impact on the concrete structure
- D: It initially weakens the concrete's internal bonds but triggers a delayed hardening process that compensates for the early vulnerability after several decades

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage describes a clear causal chain: ash + seawater -> tobermorite crystals -> fill cracks -> concrete strengthens over time. D is the strongest trap: it reverses the timeline by claiming initial weakening followed by hardening, but the passage never mentions any early weakness. A invents an impermeable layer. TRICK: Watch for options that reverse or distort the sequence of a process described in the passage.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Cognitive psychologist Soren Lindqvist conducted experiments on what he calls the 'doorway effect'--the common experience of forgetting what one intended to do upon passing through a doorway. Lindqvist asked participants to carry objects through a virtual environment, crossing through some doorways and walking equivalent distances within the same room. Participants who crossed doorways made significantly more errors recalling which object they were carrying than participants who walked the same distance without crossing a doorway. Lindqvist proposes that the brain uses doorways as 'event boundaries' that trigger the compartmentalization of ongoing mental activity, filing away the previous room's context and preparing for new information.

According to the text, what does Lindqvist propose causes people to forget after passing through a doorway?

- A: The physical effort of opening and closing a door momentarily diverts attentional resources away from the task being performed
- B: A temporary disruption in the hippocampus, the brain region responsible for converting short-term memories into long-term ones
- C: The brain treats doorways as event boundaries that trigger compartmentalization, filing away the previous context and preparing for new input
- D: A shift in visual perspective as the person enters a new spatial environment, which forces the brain to reorient its cognitive map

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Lindqvist's proposal is stated clearly: doorways act as 'event boundaries' triggering compartmentalization. B is the strongest trap: it names a real brain structure (hippocampus) and a real memory function, but neither is mentioned in the passage. A invents a physical-effort cause. D sounds plausible (spatial reorientation) but is not Lindqvist's stated mechanism. TRICK: When distractors name real scientific concepts (hippocampus, cognitive maps), students who recognize them from outside knowledge are tempted -- but the passage only supports one specific answer.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Historian Mei-Ling Zhou challenged the traditional view that the Khmer Empires decline in the fifteenth century was caused primarily by military invasions from neighboring kingdoms. Zhou analyzed tree-ring records from Southeast Asian cypress trees spanning 700 years and identified two severe megadroughts, each lasting over a decade, that coincided precisely with documented periods of urban depopulation at Angkor. Zhou argues that the collapse of the empire's elaborate hydraulic infrastructure during these droughts undermined agricultural production so severely that the population dispersed to more sustainable regions, leaving the capital vulnerable to the military incursions that followed.

Based on the text, what evidence does Zhou cite to support the claim that drought contributed to the Khmer Empires decline?

- A: Written records from neighboring kingdoms describing the conquest of Angkor during periods of weakened Khmer military strength
- B: Archaeological evidence showing that the hydraulic infrastructure at Angkor was deliberately destroyed by invading forces
- C: The dispersal of Angkors population to regions with more reliable water supplies during the fifteenth century
- D: Tree-ring data revealing two prolonged megadroughts that coincided with periods of urban depopulation at Angkor

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Zhou's EVIDENCE is the tree-ring data showing megadroughts aligned with depopulation. C is the strongest trap: population dispersal is part of Zhou's ARGUMENT (what happened as a result of drought), not her evidence (how she knows drought occurred). A describes the military invasion view she is challenging. B invents archaeological evidence not in the passage. TRICK: Distinguish between evidence (what the researcher measured or found) and the conclusion drawn from it. The tree-ring data is evidence; the population dispersal is an inference from that evidence.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Entomologist Rosa Delgado studied firefly communication in a tropical forest in Panama. Delgado observed that each firefly species produces a unique flash pattern--a specific sequence of light pulses at characteristic intervals--that allows females to identify and respond to males of their own species. Delgado also discovered that females of one predatory firefly species, *Photuris versicolor*, mimic the flash patterns of other species. When males of the mimicked species approach expecting a mate, the *Photuris* female captures and consumes them.

According to the text, why do *Photuris versicolor* females mimic other species' flash patterns?

- A: To signal to males of their own species that they are ready to mate
- B: To establish territorial boundaries that deter rival females from occupying nearby areas
- C: To lure males of other species into approaching, allowing the predatory female to capture and consume them
- D: To confuse predators by producing unpredictable light signals that make the firefly difficult to locate

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage says *Photuris* females mimic other species' patterns so males 'approach expecting a mate,' then the *Photuris* female 'captures and consumes them.' A is the purpose-reversal trap: it describes the normal function of flash patterns (attracting mates of ONE'S OWN species) but applies it to the mimicry, which serves a predatory, not reproductive, purpose. TRICK: When a passage describes a behavior that subverts the normal function of a system, the test will offer the normal function as a distractor.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Linguist Joaquin Herrera studied Silbo Gomero, a whistled form of Spanish used on the island of La Gomera in the Canary Islands. Herrera found that Silbo transmits the phonemic structure of spoken Spanish through variations in pitch, duration, and interruption of whistled tones, allowing users to communicate complex sentences--not merely simple signals--over distances of up to five kilometers in mountainous terrain where spoken words would be inaudible. Herrera notes, however, that Silbo can convey only approximately 60 percent of the information content of spoken Spanish, because certain consonant distinctions are lost in the whistled medium, requiring listeners to rely partly on context.

According to the text, what limitation does Silbo have compared to spoken Spanish?

- A: It conveys only about 60 percent of spoken Spanish information content, because some consonant distinctions cannot be reproduced in the whistled medium
- B: It is effective only over distances of less than one kilometer, making it impractical for communication across deep mountain valleys
- C: It can transmit only simple, predetermined signals and cannot convey the grammatical complexity of full sentences
- D: It requires both speakers to be fluent in at least two spoken languages in addition to the whistled code

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage says Silbo conveys 'approximately 60 percent' of spoken Spanish content because 'certain consonant distinctions are lost.' B directly contradicts the passage (5 km range, not less than 1 km). C contradicts 'complex sentences--not merely simple signals.' D invents a multilingual requirement. TRICK: The passage explicitly states both a capability AND a limitation. Distractors that deny the capability (B, C) or invent restrictions (D) contradict the text.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Geneticist Emiko Sato studied epigenetic inheritance in laboratory mice. Sato conditioned male mice to associate the scent of acetophenone--a chemical with a cherry-blossom odor--with a mild electric shock. After conditioning, these mice exhibited a fear response (freezing behavior) when exposed to acetophenone. Remarkably, the offspring of these conditioned males, who had never been exposed to the shock-scent pairing, also showed heightened startle responses specifically to acetophenone but not to other odors such as propanol. Sato found that both the conditioned fathers and their offspring showed demethylation of a gene encoding an olfactory receptor known to detect acetophenone, suggesting that the fear response was transmitted through epigenetic modifications to this specific receptor gene.

What does the text most strongly imply about the offsprings sensitivity?

- A: The offspring developed a generalized anxiety disorder that caused heightened startle responses to all unexpected sensory stimuli, not just olfactory ones
- B: The offsprings sensitivity was a learned behavior acquired through social cues from their fathers' behavior rather than through biological inheritance
- C: The offspring showed heightened responses to all chemical odors tested in the study, reflecting a broad increase in olfactory sensitivity
- D: The offsprings heightened sensitivity was specific to acetophenone and was linked to epigenetic changes in the gene for the olfactory receptor that detects that particular scent

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The passage is precise: offspring responded to acetophenone 'but not to other odors such as propanol,' and the epigenetic change was in 'a gene encoding an olfactory receptor known to detect acetophenone.' C is the strongest trap: it overgeneralizes to ALL odors, but the passage explicitly says the response was specific to acetophenone. A broadens even further to all sensory stimuli. TRICK: When a passage carefully limits a finding to one specific stimulus, the test will offer options that inflate the scope to 'all stimuli' or 'all odors.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Materials engineer Xiulan Chen developed a white paint formulated with barium sulfate nanoparticles of varying sizes. The different particle sizes scatter different wavelengths of sunlight, allowing the paint to reflect 98.1 percent of incoming solar radiation. In outdoor field tests, surfaces coated with the paint remained up to 4.5 degrees Celsius cooler than the ambient air temperature, even under direct midday sunlight. Chen notes that widespread application of the paint to building rooftops could significantly reduce electricity consumption for air conditioning in hot climates.

According to the text, how does the paint achieve its cooling effect?

- A: By absorbing solar energy and converting it into infrared radiation that is emitted away from the building surface
- B: By using barium sulfate particles of varying sizes to scatter and reflect 98.1 percent of incoming sunlight away from the coated surface
- C: By maintaining a surface temperature exactly 4.5 degrees Celsius below the surrounding air temperature at all times of day
- D: By creating an insulating air layer between the paint coating and the building surface that blocks heat transfer from the sun

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage describes the mechanism: varying particle sizes scatter different wavelengths, reflecting 98.1 percent of sunlight. C is the trap: it takes the RESULT (4.5 degrees cooler) and presents it as the mechanism, but a temperature outcome is what the paint achieves, not HOW it achieves it. A invents an absorption-and-emission process. TRICK: Distinguish between how something works (mechanism) and what it produces (result). The test will present the result as if it were the mechanism.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Economist Adaeze Okwu studied the 'resource curse'--the paradox that countries rich in natural resources such as oil and minerals often experience slower economic growth than resource-poor countries. While the conventional view attributes this paradox to corruption and poor governance enabled by resource wealth, Okwu argues that the primary mechanism is 'Dutch disease': when a country exports large quantities of a valuable natural resource, the resulting influx of foreign currency causes the national currency to appreciate sharply. This appreciation makes the country's other exports--manufactured goods, agricultural products--uncompetitive on the global market, causing those sectors to shrink. Okwu contends that this loss of economic diversification, rather than corruption, is the fundamental driver of resource-dependent stagnation.

Based on the text, what mechanism does Okwu propose as the primary cause of the resource curse?

- A: Currency appreciation driven by resource exports makes other sectors uncompetitive, destroying economic diversification
- B: Widespread governmental corruption fueled by resource wealth diverts public funds from productive investment into private enrichment
- C: Overinvestment in resource extraction depletes the natural resource base faster than new reserves can be discovered
- D: Dependence on a single export commodity leaves the economy vulnerable to sudden price drops in global commodity markets

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Okwu's mechanism is Dutch disease: resource exports -> currency appreciation -> other exports become uncompetitive -> economic diversification collapses. B is the strongest trap: corruption is the CONVENTIONAL view that Okwu explicitly REJECTS as the primary cause. Students who skim the passage may grab the familiar corruption narrative without noticing Okwu argues against it. TRICK: When a passage says 'while the conventional view is X, this researcher argues Y,' the test will offer X as a distractor. Read whose view is whose.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Kira Johansson studied patients with prosopagnosia, a condition in which individuals lose the ability to recognize faces. Johansson found that prosopagnosic patients could not identify familiar people by their facial features alone, relying instead on non-facial cues such as voice, hairstyle, and gait. However, Johansson discovered that these same patients could still accurately detect emotional expressions--such as happiness, anger, or fear--on faces they could not identify. Johansson concluded that the neural pathways for processing facial identity and facial emotion are functionally independent, since damage to the identity pathway leaves the emotion pathway intact.

According to the text, what did Johansson discover about prosopagnosic patients' ability to process facial emotions?

- A: They could detect emotions only on the faces of people they had known before the onset of their condition
- B: They could accurately detect emotional expressions on faces even though they could not identify whose face they were looking at
- C: They could no longer detect any emotional information from faces, relying entirely on vocal tone and body language to assess others' feelings
- D: They detected emotions more slowly and less accurately than individuals without prosopagnosia, though some residual ability remained

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage says patients 'could still accurately detect emotional expressions on faces they could not identify.' C is the negation trap: it says the OPPOSITE of what the passage states, claiming they could NOT detect facial emotions. D weakens the finding by adding 'less accurately,' but the passage says 'accurately.' A adds a restriction (only pre-onset acquaintances) not in the passage. TRICK: When a passage reports a surprising finding ('they CAN still do X despite losing Y'), the test will offer the unsurprising version ('they CANNOT do X') as a distractor.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Oceanographer Linnea Strand studied the effects of ocean acidification on pteropods--small marine mollusks whose calcium carbonate shells are vulnerable to dissolution in acidified seawater. Strand compared pteropod populations at two sites: one with normal ocean chemistry and one near a volcanic vent where CO₂ seepage creates naturally acidified conditions. At the vent site, pteropods survived but had shells that were approximately 30 percent thinner than those at the control site. Strand found that the vent-site pteropods compensated for the acidified conditions by increasing their rate of shell production, partially offsetting dissolution. However, Strand noted that this compensatory strategy carried a significant metabolic cost, reducing the energy available for reproduction, and that vent-site pteropod populations were substantially smaller as a result.

What does the text most strongly suggest about pteropods living near volcanic vents?

- A: They are entirely unaffected by ocean acidification because their shells are composed of a form of calcium carbonate that resists dissolution
- B: They have developed a behavioral adaptation of migrating periodically to non-acidified waters to allow their shells to recover and thicken
- C: They partially compensate for acidification by increasing shell production, but this strategy has metabolic costs that reduce reproduction and limit population size
- D: They have evolved an entirely new type of shell material that does not contain calcium carbonate, making them immune to the effects of acidified water

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage describes a partial compensation with significant trade-offs: thinner shells, faster production, metabolic cost, reduced reproduction, smaller populations. A overgeneralizes to 'entirely unaffected' -- the passage says they survive but with 30 percent thinner shells and smaller populations. D invents a new shell material. B invents a migration behavior. TRICK: When a passage describes a partial, costly adaptation, the test will offer an option that inflates it into a complete solution with no downsides.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Sociolinguist Amira Bouzid studied language use among bilingual Arabic-French professionals in Algiers. Bouzid observed that in formal workplace meetings conducted in French, bilingual employees switched to Arabic at predictable moments--specifically when discussions turned to emotionally charged topics such as personal disagreements, expressions of frustration, or sharing of confidential concerns. Bouzid proposes that this pattern reflects the greater emotional accessibility of one's first language: when emotional processing demands increase, speakers instinctively revert to the language in which emotional concepts were originally encoded during childhood.

According to the text, when did bilingual employees tend to switch from French to Arabic in workplace settings?

- A: Whenever they encountered a French word or technical term they did not know and needed to find an equivalent
- B: At the beginning and end of formal meetings, as a gesture of cultural identity and solidarity with colleagues
- C: Throughout entire meetings regardless of topic, because they preferred Arabic as their primary language of workplace communication
- D: During discussions of emotionally charged topics such as personal disagreements, frustration, or confidential concerns

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The passage specifies they switched 'when discussions turned to emotionally charged topics' -- not always, not at set times, and not for vocabulary gaps. C is the conditional-to-absolute trap: it says they used Arabic 'throughout entire meetings regardless of topic,' but the passage describes switching only at specific emotional moments. A invents a vocabulary-gap trigger. TRICK: When a passage describes behavior that occurs UNDER SPECIFIC CONDITIONS, reject any option that removes those conditions and presents the behavior as constant.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Astrophysicist Nkechi Adeyemi discovered a fast radio burst (FRB) source designated FRB-190520 that, unlike most known FRBs, emits bursts in a repeating pattern with a 16.35-day cycle. During an active phase lasting approximately four days, the source emits multiple bursts per hour; it then falls silent for roughly twelve days before resuming. Adeyemi proposes that the source is a magnetar--a highly magnetized neutron star--orbiting a massive companion star. In this model, the magnetar's radio emissions are periodically blocked when the companion star passes between the magnetar and Earth, producing the observed four-day-active, twelve-day-silent pattern.

Based on the text, what pattern does FRB-190520 exhibit?

- A: It cycles between an active phase of about four days, during which it produces multiple bursts per hour, and a silent phase of about twelve days, repeating on a 16.35-day period
- B: It emits a single powerful burst every 16.35 days, with each burst lasting approximately four seconds before the source returns to silence
- C: It produces bursts continuously without interruption but at varying intensity levels, with peak intensity occurring every 16.35 days
- D: It alternates between radio bursts and X-ray bursts on a 16.35-day cycle, with each type of emission lasting approximately eight days

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The passage describes a precise cycle: 4-day active phase (multiple bursts per hour) + 12-day silent phase = 16.35-day total cycle. B is the strongest trap: it gets the 16.35-day period right but collapses the multi-day active phase into a single burst. C removes the silent phase entirely. D invents X-ray bursts. TRICK: When a passage gives precise temporal details (duration, frequency, phases), the test will offer options that preserve one number but distort the pattern.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Architect Yuki Tanaka designed a community center in Hokkaido, Japan, using rammed earth walls--a construction technique in which moist soil is compressed into dense, load-bearing panels. The walls provide natural thermal mass, absorbing heat from sunlight during the day and releasing it gradually at night, which reduces the building's dependence on mechanical heating systems during Hokkaido's severe winters. Tanaka notes that rammed earth construction dates back over 3,000 years in East Asia, but she has updated the technique using modern structural analysis and seismic reinforcement methods appropriate for Japan's earthquake-prone geography.

According to the text, what thermal property do rammed earth walls provide?

- A: They generate heat through an internal chemical reaction triggered by the compression of soil during construction
- B: They absorb heat during the day and release it gradually at night, functioning as natural thermal mass that reduces the need for mechanical heating
- C: They block all heat transfer between the buildings interior and exterior, maintaining a constant temperature regardless of outside conditions
- D: They were developed by Tanaka as a completely new construction method with no historical precedent in Japanese or East Asian architecture

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The passage states the walls 'absorb heat during the day and release it gradually at night.' D is the misattribution trap: the passage explicitly says the technique 'dates back over 3,000 years in East Asia' -- Tanaka adapted it, she did not invent it. C overstates ('block ALL heat transfer'). A invents a chemical reaction. TRICK: When a passage credits a researcher with ADAPTING an ancient technique, a distractor will credit them with INVENTING it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Detail

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Philosopher of science Helena Varga argues that scientific models are not literal descriptions of reality but what she calls 'selective representations'--tools that deliberately capture certain patterns while ignoring others. Varga illustrates this with climate models: they accurately project global average temperature trends decades into the future yet cannot predict whether it will rain in a specific city next Tuesday. Varga contends that this selective accuracy is not a flaw but an inherent feature of all scientific modeling. A model that attempted to represent every aspect of reality simultaneously would be as complex as reality itself and therefore useless as a simplifying tool. The value of a model, Varga argues, lies precisely in what it chooses to leave out.

Based on the text, what does Varga argue about the relationship between scientific models and reality?

A: Models are fundamentally unreliable because their predictions have been shown to fail more often than they succeed across all scientific disciplines

B: Models are temporary approximations that scientists intend to replace with complete descriptions of reality as technology advances

C: Models are objective, unbiased mirrors of natural systems that capture reality with minimal distortion when properly constructed

D: Models are selective tools that deliberately represent certain patterns while omitting others, and their usefulness depends on this selectivity rather than on complete accuracy

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Varga calls models 'selective representations' whose value lies 'precisely in what they choose to leave out.' A overstates to 'fundamentally unreliable,' but Varga says models are valuable and accurate in their chosen domain. C calls models 'objective mirrors,' but Varga's entire argument is that models are deliberately selective, not comprehensive. B says models are 'temporary,' but Varga treats selectivity as an inherent, permanent feature. TRICK: When a philosopher makes a nuanced claim ('selective but valuable'), the test offers extreme versions: 'completely unreliable' (A), 'perfectly objective' (C), or 'temporary until perfected' (B).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Psychologist Miriam Ashford has argued that regular aerobic exercise reduces symptoms of clinical depression more effectively than stretching-only routines of equal duration.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Ashford's claim?

- A: Participants who completed aerobic exercise sessions reported enjoying the sessions more than participants who completed stretching sessions
- B: Participants assigned to aerobic exercise attended their scheduled sessions at a higher rate than participants assigned to stretching routines
- C: After twelve weeks, participants randomly assigned to aerobic exercise showed a significantly greater reduction in clinically measured depression symptoms than participants randomly assigned to duration-matched stretching routines
- D: Participants in both the aerobic exercise group and the stretching group reported higher overall life satisfaction at the end of the study than they had at the beginning

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Ashford claims aerobic exercise reduces DEPRESSION SYMPTOMS more than stretching. C tests exactly this: randomized groups, depression measurement, aerobic > stretching. A measures enjoyment (wrong outcome). B measures attendance (wrong outcome). D shows both groups improved on life satisfaction, which does not distinguish between them.

TRICK: Support must measure the EXACT outcome named in the claim. Enjoyment, attendance, and life satisfaction are different from depression symptoms.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Letters from a Divided City is a 2008 novel by Sasha Volkov. The narrator characterizes the protagonist, Irina, as intellectually brilliant but emotionally detached--someone whose sharp analytical mind allows her to dissect any problem while remaining personally uninvolved in the suffering of those around her: _____

Which quotation from Letters from a Divided City most effectively illustrates the claim?

A: "Irina solved the supply crisis in an afternoon, reorganizing the entire distribution chain on the back of an envelope while the others argued, but when Katya broke down weeping at the news about her brother, Irina glanced up only briefly before returning to her calculations."

B: "Irina spent the whole evening rearranging the bookshelves in her apartment, sorting the volumes first by subject, then by publication date, then by author, until every spine was perfectly aligned."

C: "Katya had always admired Irina and told everyone so, though she sometimes wondered whether the admiration was mutual or whether Irina even noticed."

D: "Irina walked the length of the bridge and back each morning, rain or shine, and this was the only ritual she maintained with any consistency."

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The claim: intellectually brilliant AND emotionally detached. A shows both: solving a crisis in an afternoon on an envelope (brilliance) AND glancing up only briefly at Katya's weeping before returning to calculations (detachment). B is the strongest trap: it shows Irina being meticulous and analytical (sorting books obsessively), which could suggest an analytical mind, but it shows NO interpersonal emotional detachment -- she is alone. TRICK: Two-part claims need BOTH parts in one quotation. B shows orderliness without emotional context; only A shows brilliance deployed ALONGSIDE detachment from human suffering.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Environmental scientist Paolo Marchetti has argued that planting trees along urban streets reduces air pollution specifically by capturing airborne particulate matter on leaf surfaces, where it is later washed to the ground by rain.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Marchetti's claim?

A: Streets lined with trees tend to have lower ambient temperatures during summer months, which reduces the formation of ground-level ozone

B: Urban areas with more tree coverage report higher levels of resident satisfaction with neighborhood environmental quality

C: Tree-lined streets experience less traffic congestion than streets without trees, resulting in lower vehicle emissions per kilometer

D: Electron microscope analysis of leaves collected from urban street trees revealed dense deposits of particulate matter on leaf surfaces, and air quality measurements showed significantly lower particulate concentrations on tree-lined streets after rainfall events compared to before rainfall

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Marchetti's specific mechanism: leaves capture particles, rain washes them down. D confirms both steps: particles found on leaves AND air quality improves after rain. A describes a real benefit of trees (cooling reduces ozone) but tests a DIFFERENT mechanism than Marchetti's particle-capture claim. C suggests trees reduce pollution by reducing traffic, not by capturing particles. TRICK: When a claim names a specific mechanism, a distractor describing the right topic (trees reducing pollution) but a different mechanism (cooling, traffic reduction) does not support the specific claim.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Hana Kurosawa has argued that sleep deprivation specifically impairs the ability to make moral judgments that require weighing competing interests--such as deciding whether to sacrifice one person's welfare to benefit a larger group--while leaving simpler moral judgments, such as recognizing that unprovoked theft is wrong, relatively unaffected.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Kurosawa's argument?

- A: Sleep-deprived participants reported feeling more fatigued and less motivated to engage with the experimental tasks than well-rested participants
- B: Sleep-deprived participants performed significantly worse than rested participants on moral dilemmas requiring them to weigh competing interests, but showed no impairment on straightforward moral judgments involving clear right-and-wrong distinctions
- C: Sleep-deprived participants performed worse than rested participants on all categories of cognitive tasks, including moral reasoning, mathematical computation, and reading comprehension
- D: Well-rested participants solved complex moral dilemmas faster than sleep-deprived participants, though both groups ultimately reached the same conclusions

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Kurosawa claims sleep deprivation SPECIFICALLY impairs complex moral weighing while leaving simple judgments intact. B shows exactly this pattern. C is the strongest trap: it shows sleep deprivation impairs EVERYTHING, which would not support Kurosawa's claim about moral-judgment specificity. A shows fatigue (a different measure). D shows speed differences but identical conclusions (no impairment in judgment quality). TRICK: When a claim says 'X specifically impairs Y but not Z,' evidence that X impairs everything equally does NOT support specificity.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The Amber Province is a 2017 novel by Daria Sokolova. The narrator describes the character Mikhail as someone whose apparent generosity always serves a deeper need to control the people around him--he gives freely but expects absolute loyalty in return, and his gifts carry unspoken obligations: _____

Which quotation from The Amber Province most effectively illustrates the claim?

A: "Mikhail counted out the bills carefully, making sure the amount was exact, and placed them in an envelope marked with the date and the recipients name."

B: "Everyone in the village knew that Mikhail would help without being asked, and they loved him for it without reservation."

C: "Mikhail paid for the familys entire harvest debt without being asked, then sat at their table and explained, gently but firmly, that he now expected to be consulted before they made any decisions about the land."

D: "The old woman thanked Mikhail for the firewood, and he waved her gratitude away with a smile, saying it was nothing."

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The claim: generosity concealing a need for control, with gifts carrying unspoken obligations. C shows both: paying a debt without being asked (generosity) THEN requiring to be consulted on all land decisions (control via obligation). B is the hardest trap: it shows generosity 'without being asked' and people loving him 'without reservation' -- but it shows only the generous surface, not the controlling demand underneath. D also shows generosity without control. TRICK: 'Concealed motivation' claims require the quotation to show BOTH the surface behavior AND the hidden layer. A quote showing only the surface half fails.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Education researcher Kwasi Appiah has argued that dual-language immersion programs--in which students receive instruction in both their native language and a second language throughout the school day--improve academic outcomes in BOTH languages compared to English-only instruction, because literacy skills developed in one language transfer to the other.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Appiah's argument?

A: Students enrolled in dual-language programs scored higher than English-only peers on standardized reading assessments in both English and Spanish at the end of third grade, and a regression analysis showed that gains in Spanish reading predicted corresponding gains in English reading within the same students

B: Students enrolled in dual-language programs scored higher than English-only peers on standardized reading assessments in Spanish but showed no significant difference in English reading scores

C: Parents of students in dual-language programs reported higher satisfaction with their childrens education than parents of students in English-only programs

D: Schools that offered dual-language programs had lower student-to-teacher ratios and higher per-student spending than schools offering English-only instruction

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Appiah claims dual-language programs improve outcomes in BOTH languages via skill transfer. A confirms all three elements: better scores in both languages AND transfer evidence (Spanish gains predict English gains). B is the strongest trap: it shows improvement in only ONE language (Spanish), which fails Appiahs both languages' claim. C measures satisfaction, not academic outcomes. D introduces confounding variables. TRICK: When a claim says 'improves X AND Y,' evidence showing improvement in X only is insufficient.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Urban planner Josephine Okafor has argued that installing public art in underinvested neighborhoods directly increases civic engagement--measured by voter turnout, attendance at community meetings, and participation in neighborhood associations--because the art installations foster a sense of community pride and shared identity.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Okafor's argument?

A: The cost of installing and maintaining public art in underinvested neighborhoods was significantly higher than original budget estimates in most cases

B: Residents of neighborhoods with public art installations reported higher aesthetic satisfaction with their surroundings than residents of neighborhoods without installations

C: Public art installations in already-affluent neighborhoods did not produce any measurable increase in civic engagement among residents

D: The neighborhoods selected for public art installations were chosen specifically because they already had active neighborhood associations and high civic participation rates, and a matched comparison with equally underinvested neighborhoods that had similar baseline civic engagement but did not receive art showed no significant difference in engagement trends over five years

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Okafor claims art CAUSES increased civic engagement. D reveals two devastating problems: (1) neighborhoods were chosen BECAUSE they already had high civic participation (selection bias), and (2) a proper comparison group showed no difference over time. This proves the correlation between art and engagement reflects selection, not causation. B supports part of Okafor's mechanism (aesthetic satisfaction) but does not address civic engagement. C tests affluent areas (different population).

TRICK: 'X causes Y' is weakened by showing Y was already present before X was introduced AND that a proper control group shows no effect.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The Carpenters Daughter is a 2012 novel by Andres Salgado. The narrator portrays the protagonist, Valentina, as someone whose gruff, practical exterior conceals a deep aesthetic sensitivity that she reveals only in unguarded moments:

Which quotation from The Carpenters Daughter most effectively illustrates the claim?

A: "Valentina measured the boards twice, cut once, and never wasted a nail, and the other workers respected her for it."

B: "When the foreman asked about the blueprints, Valentina produced them immediately, every measurement annotated in her precise, angular handwriting."

C: "Valentina told the apprentice to stop talking and finish sanding, her voice flat and impatient--but later, when she thought no one was looking, she ran her fingers along the grain of the walnut panel and stood motionless for a full minute, studying the way the late light moved across its surface."

D: "Valentina rarely spoke about anything other than the work, and the apprentices learned early that personal questions would be met with silence."

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The claim: gruff practical exterior CONCEALING aesthetic sensitivity revealed only in unguarded moments. C shows all three layers: gruff exterior (flat, impatient voice), practical competence (directing the apprentice), AND hidden sensitivity (secretly studying the light on wood grain when she thinks she is unobserved). A and B show practical competence without any aesthetic sensitivity. D shows gruffness without the hidden artistic layer. TRICK: 'Concealed sensitivity' requires the quotation to show the concealment AND the reveal. Options showing only the tough exterior miss the hidden dimension.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Cognitive psychologist Lena Gruber has argued that spaced practice--distributing study sessions across multiple days--produces significantly better long-term retention than massed practice--concentrating the same total study time into a single session.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Grubers claim?

- A: Students who studied for three hours total performed better on a retention test than students who did not study at all
- B: Students who studied for one hour on each of three separate days scored significantly higher on a retention test administered two weeks later than students who studied for three continuous hours on a single day
- C: Students who used spaced practice reported finding the study material less tedious than students who used massed practice
- D: Students who studied for six hours using spaced practice performed better than students who studied for three hours using spaced practice

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Gruber claims spaced > massed for long-term retention. B tests exactly this: same total time (3 hours), different distribution (spaced vs. massed), retention measured later (2 weeks). A is the wrong-comparison trap: it compares studying vs. NOT studying, which does not test spaced vs. massed. C measures tedium, not retention. D compares different amounts of spaced practice (not spaced vs. massed). TRICK: The support must test the EXACT comparison in the claim: same total time, different distribution. Any other comparison is off-target.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Ravi Chakraborty has proposed that mirror neurons--brain cells that fire both when a person performs an action and when the person observes someone else performing the same action--are the neural basis of emotional empathy. Chakraborty argues that mirror neurons allow individuals to internally simulate the emotional states of others by automatically reproducing the observed person's facial expressions and bodily postures at a neural level, generating a corresponding emotional experience in the observer.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Chakraborty's proposal?

A: Individuals with more active mirror neuron systems were better at imitating complex physical movements demonstrated by a researcher, such as hand gestures and dance sequences

B: Brain imaging showed that mirror neurons were equally active when participants observed both emotional and non-emotional actions, such as someone picking up a cup

C: Participants who scored highest on self-report empathy questionnaires also reported the most vivid mental imagery during a separate visualization task

D: Individuals with greater mirror neuron activity during observation of others' emotional expressions reported more intense corresponding emotional responses and scored significantly higher on behavioral tests of emotional empathy, while individuals with suppressed mirror neuron activity showed reduced emotional resonance with observed expressions

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Chakraborty claims mirror neurons underlie EMOTIONAL empathy via internal simulation of emotions. D shows the full chain: more mirror activity during emotional observation -> more emotional response -> higher empathy scores, AND the reverse (suppressed activity -> reduced resonance). A is the strongest trap: it shows mirror neurons help with MOTOR imitation (hand gestures, dance), not emotional empathy. B actually weakens by showing mirror neurons respond to non-emotional actions equally. TRICK: When a claim attributes a specific function (emotional empathy) to a brain system, evidence of a DIFFERENT function (motor imitation) does not support the specific claim.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 26

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: *Winter on the Ridge* is a 1994 novel by Margaret Calloway. The narrator describes the character Eleanor as fiercely independent in her public life but secretly lonely--someone who projects self-sufficiency so convincingly that no one realizes how much she longs for companionship: _____

Which quotation from *Winter on the Ridge* most effectively illustrates the claim?

A: "Eleanor changed her own tires in the driveway while the neighbors watched from their porches, and when old Mr. Harlan offered to help she told him she had been doing it since she was sixteen and did not intend to stop now."

B: "In the evenings Eleanor read by the fire, content with the silence and the company of her two dogs, who lay at her feet as they always had."

C: "Eleanor refused every dinner invitation that winter with the same polite firmness, but on the nights when the phone did not ring at all she sat by the kitchen window and watched the lights come on in the houses down the road until it was too dark to see."

D: "The town trusted Eleanor to run the fundraiser because she was organized, decisive, and would not tolerate excuses from volunteers."

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The claim: fiercely independent publicly BUT secretly lonely. C shows both: refusing invitations (public independence) AND watching neighbors' lights alone, waiting for the phone (secret loneliness). A is the hardest trap: it shows fierce independence (changing tires, refusing help) but NO loneliness -- she seems genuinely self-sufficient. B shows contentment with solitude, which directly CONTRADICTS secret loneliness. TRICK: 'Secretly lonely' requires a moment where the character's private behavior reveals a desire for connection that contradicts their public self-sufficiency. Genuine contentment (B) and competent self-reliance (A) both fail this test.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 27

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Management researcher Fatima Nassar has argued that teams whose members bring diverse professional backgrounds and areas of expertise produce more innovative solutions to complex problems than teams whose members share similar training and experience.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Nassar's claim?

A: Cross-functional teams composed of members from engineering, marketing, and design departments generated 40 percent more patentable ideas per quarter than teams drawn entirely from a single department, with the total number of team members held constant across both conditions

B: Larger teams of eight or more members generated more total ideas than smaller teams of three to four members, regardless of the diversity of members' professional backgrounds

C: Team members with diverse backgrounds reported that they found their work more intellectually stimulating than members of homogeneous teams

D: Companies that invested more in team-building activities reported higher overall employee satisfaction and lower turnover rates

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Nassar claims DIVERSITY of backgrounds -> more innovative solutions. A tests this with team size controlled: diverse teams generated 40 percent more patentable ideas than single-department teams of equal size. B is the strongest trap: it shows larger teams produce more ideas, but attributes this to SIZE, not diversity. C measures stimulation, not innovation output. D measures satisfaction, not innovation. TRICK: When the claim is about DIVERSITY, evidence about SIZE, enjoyment, or satisfaction does not test the right variable.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 28

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Health psychologist Arjun Desai conducted a study in which adults who voluntarily enrolled in an eight-week mindfulness meditation course showed a 30 percent reduction in blood levels of C-reactive protein, an inflammatory marker associated with cardiovascular risk. Desai concluded that mindfulness meditation directly reduces systemic inflammation.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Desai's conclusion?

- A: Participants who attended more meditation sessions showed greater reductions in C-reactive protein than participants who attended fewer sessions
- B: C-reactive protein levels fluctuate naturally over time and can be influenced by seasonal changes in diet, exercise, and sleep patterns
- C: The meditation instructor who led the course was a highly experienced practitioner with over twenty years of teaching experience
- D: Participants who enrolled in the meditation course also independently made significant changes to their diets, exercise habits, and sleep schedules during the same eight-week period, and statistical analysis showed that these lifestyle changes, rather than meditation attendance, were the primary predictors of the reduction in C-reactive protein levels

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Desai concludes meditation CAUSED the inflammation reduction. D shows participants also changed their diets, exercise, and sleep, and these changes -- not meditation -- predicted the CRP drop. A actually STRENGTHENS (dose-response). B introduces natural fluctuation as a general concern but does not specifically explain THIS study's results. C is irrelevant to the causal claim. TRICK: Voluntary wellness programs attract people already motivated to improve their health. If they change multiple behaviors simultaneously, no single change can be credited.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 29

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Political scientist Adaora Ibe has argued that colonial-era borders in sub-Saharan Africa that divided pre-existing ethnic groups across two or more countries are a significant cause of modern armed conflicts in those border regions, because the divided communities maintain cross-border loyalties that compete with national allegiance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Ibe's argument?

A: Countries in sub-Saharan Africa that were colonized by different European powers have experienced different rates of economic growth since independence

B: Border regions where pre-colonial ethnic groups were split across two countries experienced armed conflict at three times the rate of border regions where the colonial boundary did not divide any ethnic group, after controlling for economic conditions and terrain

C: Sub-Saharan African countries with more ethnic groups within their borders tend to have higher overall rates of political instability

D: Many colonial-era borders in sub-Saharan Africa follow straight lines that ignore natural geographic features such as rivers and mountain ranges

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Ibe's specific claim: borders that DIVIDED ethnic groups cause conflict in those regions. B tests exactly this by comparing divided vs. non-divided border regions, finding three times the conflict rate where groups were split. C is the strongest trap: it mentions ethnic diversity and instability, but Ibe's argument is about DIVIDED groups at borders specifically, not total ethnic count within a country. D describes borders' arbitrary nature but does not test whether division causes conflict. TRICK: When a claim specifies 'X type of Y causes Z,' evidence about Y generally (all borders, all ethnic diversity) does not test the specific X-type mechanism.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 30

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Claim-Example Match

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The Orchard Keeper is a 1998 novel by Tomoko Ishida. The narrator portrays the character Haruki as someone whose outward devotion to his family's traditions masks a private ambivalence--he performs every ritual with visible reverence, yet the narrator reveals that he inwardly questions whether the traditions still hold meaning: _____

Which quotation from The Orchard Keeper most effectively illustrates the claim?

A: "Haruki lit the incense at the family altar each morning, as his father and grandfather had done before him, and he found comfort in the continuity of the gesture."

B: "Haruki told his daughter that tradition was the foundation of everything good in their family, and she believed him because he said it with such certainty."

C: "Haruki bowed before the altar with the same deliberate precision his grandfather had taught him, arranged the offerings exactly as they had always been arranged, and spoke the words without a single error--but as he closed the doors of the altar cabinet he paused, his hand resting on the wood, wondering for the hundredth time whether the words meant anything at all or whether he was only performing a shape that had lost its center."

D: "The orchard had been in the family for four generations, and Haruki maintained it with the same care his predecessors had, pruning each tree according to the old methods."

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The claim: outward devotion masking private ambivalence about whether traditions still hold meaning. C shows both layers simultaneously: meticulous ritual performance (bowing, arranging offerings, speaking words perfectly) followed by a private moment of doubt ('wondering whether the words meant anything at all or whether he was only performing a shape that had lost its center'). A is the hardest trap: it shows ritual performance AND says he 'found comfort' in it--but comfort is the OPPOSITE of ambivalence. B shows him performing certainty for his daughter but reveals no private doubt. TRICK: 'Masks ambivalence' requires the quotation to show BOTH the convincing performance AND the hidden doubt. An option showing genuine comfort (A) or genuine certainty (B) contradicts the 'masking' element.

END QUESTION